

The First 90 Day Driver Retention Playbook.

The exact 9-touchpoint SMS framework that reduces first-90-day turnover for trucking carriers.

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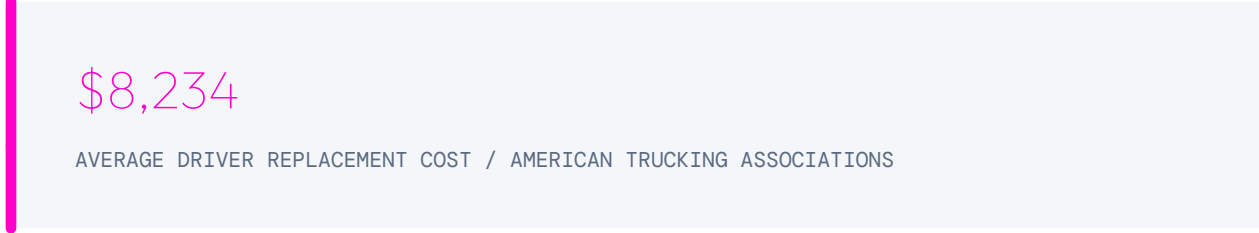
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CHAPTER 01 / THE WINDOW

Why the First 90 Days Matter

35% of new drivers leave a carrier before they hit Day 90 (Stay Metrics). That single window contains more turnover than the rest of the year combined for most fleets. After 90 days, retention rates stabilize sharply.

The reason is simple. New hires have no loyalty yet. They are evaluating whether the job matches what they were promised in recruiting. If nobody checks in, nobody recognizes them, and nobody makes them feel like they belong, they start looking. Often quietly. Often before anyone at the carrier knows there is a problem.



\$8,234

AVERAGE DRIVER REPLACEMENT COST / AMERICAN TRUCKING ASSOCIATIONS

Every driver lost in the first 90 days is the full replacement cost (\$8,234 per the ATA) with zero return on the recruiting and onboarding investment that got them in the door. Multiply that across a fleet that hires 100 drivers a year and the math gets uncomfortable fast.

The good news. The first 90 days are also the most predictable window in a driver's tenure. You know exactly when each milestone falls. You know exactly when risk peaks. You can build a system that meets a driver at every one of those moments without anyone on your team having to remember to do it.

That system is what this playbook is. Nine touchpoints. One channel. Ninety days.

CHAPTER 02 / THE FRAMEWORK

The 9-Touchpoint Sequence

A structured SMS communication sequence designed to keep new hires engaged from Day 1 through Day 90. Every message is sent via text to the driver's phone from a number branded to your carrier. No app required. No login. No friction.

DAY	TOUCHPOINT	GOAL
1	Welcome	Make the driver feel expected and valued from minute one.
7	First Week Check-in	Ask how things are going. Simple reply prompt.
14	Leadership Intro	Short message from owner or manager. Makes leadership human.
21	Dispatcher Check	Ask specifically about dispatch communication.
30	30-Day Milestone	First celebration. Branded graphic via SMS.
45	Mid-Point Pulse	Open question: what do you wish you knew before starting?
60	60-Day Milestone	Two months strong. Recognition message.
80	Final Check-in	How are things overall. Last chance to catch issues.
90	90-Day Completion	Full celebration. Branded milestone page.

Each touchpoint alternates between two patterns. Some are recognition moments (Day 1, 14, 30, 60, 90) where the driver receives something. Some are reply prompts (Day 7, 21, 45, 80) where you ask a specific question and listen. The alternation matters. A pure broadcast sequence feels like spam. A pure interrogation sequence feels invasive. The mix builds a rhythm.

CHAPTER 03 / THE TEMPLATES

Ready-to-Use SMS Templates

The exact copy we use in the field, with notes on why each message works. Customize the company name, driver name, and links. Keep the structure.

DAY 1 / WELCOME MESSAGE

Welcome to [Company Name], [First Name]. We are glad you are here. Your first weeks matter to us, so expect a check-in from time to time. Here is a quick welcome from our team: [link]

Why it works. Sets the tone that this carrier communicates proactively. The link gives them something tangible within hours of orientation.

DAY 7 / FIRST WEEK CHECK-IN

Hey [First Name], one week in. How is everything going so far? Anything we can help with? Just reply to this message.

Why it works. Drivers who respond at Day 7 are significantly more likely to stay through Day 90. Non-responders become your earliest warning signal. Track them.

DAY 14 / LEADERSHIP INTRODUCTION

Two weeks strong, [First Name]. Here is a quick message from [Owner Name], our [title]. They wanted to say hey personally: [link]

Why it works. Drivers at most carriers never hear from leadership. A 30-second phone video from the owner makes the company feel personal even at 500 trucks.

DAY 21 / DISPATCHER RELATIONSHIP CHECK

Quick one, [First Name]. How has communication been with your dispatcher? We want to make sure that relationship is working for you. Reply anytime.

Why it works. Dispatch communication is the most cited reason drivers leave. A negative reply here is a gift, not a threat. It is the earliest possible signal you can act on.

DAY 30 / 30-DAY MILESTONE



[First Name], you just hit your first month at [Company Name]. That is a milestone worth recognizing. Check this out: [\[link to branded milestone page\]](#)

Why it works. First celebration moment. A branded graphic with their name on it hits differently than a generic email. The page should be screenshot-friendly so they share it.

CHAPTER 04 / CLOSING THE WINDOW

Days 45 to 90

The final four touchpoints follow the same pattern as the first five. Check in, recognize, ask an open question, celebrate. By this point the driver knows the rhythm. They expect to hear from you. That expectation is the system working.

DAY 45 / MID-POINT PULSE

[First Name], you are nearly halfway through your first 90 days. What is one thing you wish you had known before starting at [Company Name]?

Why it works. Open-ended, non-threatening. Surfaces the insights that exit interviews miss. Save the answers. They are gold for your recruiting team and your operations team.

DAY 60 / 60-DAY MILESTONE

Two months strong, [First Name]. You are building something real here. Keep going.

Why it works. Recognition. Short. Direct. No link, no ask. Just acknowledgment from a company that is paying attention.

DAY 80 / FINAL CHECK-IN

Hey [First Name], how are things going overall? Anything we can do better? Last check before you hit 90.

Why it works. Last structured chance to catch a problem before the 90-day mark. If something has been brewing, this is when it surfaces. Take any reply seriously.

DAY 90 / COMPLETION

You made it through 90 days at [Company Name], [First Name]. That matters. Check out your milestone: [link]

Why it works. Full celebration. The driver is now past the highest-risk window. The branded page is shareable. Some drivers will post it. That is free recruiting content.

CHAPTER 05 / WHEN A DRIVER PUSHES BACK

The Negative Reply Playbook

The system works because drivers reply honestly. Some of those replies will be hard. A driver who tells you they are frustrated is not a problem. They are a gift. They are telling you what is wrong before they walk. Most drivers do not. They just leave.

Here is what to do when you get a hard reply. Same playbook every time.

01 / STOP

Do not reply with a template. Do not auto-respond. A real person needs to read it.

02 / CALL WITHIN 24 HOURS

Phone call, not text. The driver took the risk of telling you. Match the energy. Make it personal.

03 / ASK ONE QUESTION

"Tell me what is going on." Then listen. Do not defend. Do not explain. Just listen until they are done.

04 / DOCUMENT

Write down what they said in their words. Not your summary. Their words. You will need these notes in 30 days.

05 / FOLLOW UP IN 48 HOURS

Tell them what you did with what they said. Even if the answer is "we cannot fix that, here is why," they need to know you took it seriously.

The carriers that retain drivers are not the ones with the fewest complaints. They are the ones that respond fastest when complaints come in. Speed is the message.

CHAPTER 06 / THE METRICS

What to Track

Four numbers tell you whether the system is working. Track these weekly. If any of them slip, the rest of the system slips with them.

METRIC	TARGET	WHY IT MATTERS
Day 7 response rate	40-60%	Earliest indicator of engagement. Non-responders need outreach.
Overall response rate	30-40%	Drivers who reply to 3+ touchpoints retain at significantly higher rates.
Negative sentiment replies	< 15%	Replies scored 1-2 of 5. These drivers need a personal call within 48 hours.
Day 90 retention rate	> 80%	The whole point. Industry baseline is 65%. Your goal is to beat it.

A simple tracking sheet works. One row per driver, one column per touchpoint, mark sent/replied/sentiment. Once a week, count the columns. That is your dashboard.

CHAPTER 07 / RUNNING IT

How to Actually Send These

The framework is the easy part. Execution is where most carriers stall. Three honest options for sending these messages, ranked by what they cost in time and money.

OPTION A / MANUAL

Send each message by hand from a designated phone or Google Voice number. Free. Works for fleets under 25 trucks if one person owns it and never misses a day. Falls apart above 25.

OPTION B / DIY WITH TWILIO

Set up a Twilio account, register a 10DLC number, build or buy a scheduling tool, write the copy, monitor replies, score sentiment by hand. Maybe \$200/month at low volume. Real engineering and compliance work. Realistic for carriers with a developer on staff.

OPTION C / DONE FOR YOU

Sign up for a managed retention platform. We make one (Seated Signal). Others exist. The case for managed: somebody else writes the copy, monitors the replies, scores sentiment, and surfaces the drivers who need a call. You make the calls. The case against: it costs more than running it yourself.

Most carriers who try Option A or B abandon them in 60 days. Not because the framework does not work. Because executing daily is unforgiving. The drivers who needed a Day 21 message but did not get one are the same drivers who quit on Day 47.

CHAPTER 08 / WHAT NEXT

You Have the Playbook. Now What?

You can run this yourself. Most of what is in this document is open-source thinking applied to a closed-source problem. We did not invent the 90-day window. We built a system around it. The system in this PDF is the system we run with our pilot carrier R&R; Transportation.

If running it yourself sounds like a lot, we run it for you. Setup, copy, sending, sentiment scoring, flag monitoring. Your team makes the calls when a flag fires. We handle everything else.

\$100 for 30 days.

No card. No autoplay sales pitch. We turn it on for one of your driver classes for thirty days. You see what we see. You decide if it is worth keeping.

Reach out.

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